POLITICAL SAFARI



Is another Thackeray readying for a political debut? Uddhav Thackeray's younger son **Tejas** has been making appearances at Shiv Sena (UBT) protests in Mumbai, fuelling the speculation. The resemblance to his late grandfather, Bal Thackeray, at least in aggression and mannerisms, has added to the chatter. The party is in a difficult phase, so any help is welcome. But there is a complication. Tejas is a naturalist, more familiar with the forests of the Sahyadris than the rough and tumble of Mumbai politics. The young man may soon discover that the political jungle has some rather unfamiliar creatures.

SWEET NOTHINGS



After welcoming 20 rebel Trinamool Congress MPs, the little-known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) seems keen to convert its NDA association in Delhi into an alliance in Kolkata. NCPI MP **Sudip Bandyopadhyay** says the party will contest the municipal polls with the ruling BJP. West Bengal BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya, though, sees no need for new company. But now comes a twist. On Lakshmi Puja day, CM **Suvendu Adhikari** visited Sudip's home, offered prayers and ate two sweet *narus*. Just a courtesy call, the CM insisted. Indeed, the buzz is that the festive spirit may not extend to a share of the municipal poll pie.

MASS UNCERTAINTY



Congress general secretary (organisation) **K.C. Venugopal**'s instruction that the party's Rajasthan unit rustle up 100,000 people for the November 1 'Vote Bachao, Desh Bachao' rally in Delhi has left state leaders worried. With panchayat polls at a critical stage, the cadres are busy campaigning and guarding party candidates and independents against poaching. Nor is mobilisation looking easy. Rahul Gandhi's call for protests in Jaipur over the alleged assault on party worker Ritu Barala drew a disappointing turnout last week.

Kaushik Deka **with** ***Amitabh Srivastava, Avaneesh Mishra, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar*** **and** ***Rohit Parihar***

ECO WATCH

THE GREAT INDIAN BUSTARD
DANGERS IN THE WILD

By **Rohit Parihar**

The killing of one of the four captive-bred Great Indian Bustard (GIB) chicks within days of their release into the wild in the Thar Desert of Jaisalmer has disappointed officials and scientists involved in the conservation programme.

One of the world's heaviest flying birds, the GIB chicks were chosen for release at six months of age to give them a better chance of learning natural survival skills (older birds tend to develop stronger human imprints). Now flying in and out of a fenced semi-enclosure, the birds are encountering wildlife, people and machines for the first time. But even inside the enclosure, they have to deal with predators—desert foxes and a number of reptiles.

Gobind Sagar Bhardwaj, director of the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), Dehradun, the key agency involved in the project, has dismissed suggestions from some quarters that the foxes be removed. "We do not intend to go against scientific norms by interfering with the natural ecosystem. There will be natural selection, and we are confident that these birds will learn to cope with the challenges," he told INDIA TODAY.

A major challenge is that GIBs are very shy. Females are known to abandon their eggs when they spot humans, grazing cattle or vehicles even hundred of metres away. Such behaviour has contributed to the declining numbers.



Meanwhile, the conservation programme is prioritising the mitigation of human-induced threats, particularly collisions with power cables and human disturbance. The soft-release process, in which captive-bred birds are gradually introduced to the wild, will continue.